and his supporters on the grounds that Beijing had reneged on its 1951 agreement on respecting Tibet's cultural and religious autonomy. Yet Chinese government documents from a little later claimed that India still had designs to make Tibet a 'colony or protectorate'. Such paranoia was fuelled by a revival of Maoism. [98] Somewhat incongruently, despite the downward trajectory in India–China relations, India under V.K. Krishna Menon and Nehru continued to support China's entry into the United Nations. [99] They continued to be of the belief that bringing China into the international mainstream would make Beijing more likely to abide by rules and norms.

In August of 1959, clashes broke out between Chinese and Indian border security forces at Longju, a move that prompted the Indian Army to assume responsibility for security on the China border and to start preparing contingency war plans. India immediately put all Intelligence Bureau and Assam Rifles patrols under the direct command of the army. [100] In October, an Indian patrol was ambushed at Kongka-La in Ladakh, resulting in more hostile Indian public opinion. The next month, China proposed a demilitarized zone, but this was rejected by India because it favoured the PLA. Trust had been eroded and China had previously been vague about its claim lines. The delay in China's repatriation of Indians killed in action contributed to the souring mood, including in India's Parliament. Meanwhile, China rejected a counterproposal from India concerning patrols. All of this, including Nehru's release of correspondence with China to the Parliament and public, resulted in a hardening of India's position on Aksai Chin. [101]

In 1960, Zhou made a deliberately vague offer of 'reciprocal acceptance of present realities in both sectors' implying a swap: New Delhi would accept Aksai Chin as part of China and Beijing would accept NEFA as part of India. Mao may have authorized such an overture to India given his greater security concerns in Korea, Taiwan, and Indochina and domestic political turmoil. The offer was rejected by Nehru, who understood the hardening of the Indian political position on Aksai Chin and the requirements of parliamentary approval for territorial changes. [102] There